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## Man vs. Machine in Newsreader War


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RYAN SINGEL FROM Wired.com rants about how machines could never replace man. Reality or the ravings of a luddite?

Man vs. machine stories are an old standby in journalism.

Think back to John Henry racing a steam drill and forward to Garry Kasparov trying to outmaneuver IBM's Deep Blue in 1997 to the Onion tweaking the genre with its accountant battles Excel story.

But the latest twist on the meme takes it to the meta-level by raising the question: in the future, will you find your man vs. machine story relying on a human-edited source or from an algorithm?

Standing up for the human intellect, upstart Digg is betting that its formidable legion of users can find better and more interesting news faster than any algorithm Google—or a number of upstart companies—can code.

"I have to admit when we first started experimenting with this a year ago, the verdict was out whether (human filtering) was a benefit or a detriment," CEO Jay Adelson said. "We found that it works, that it works really, really well.... We think people do a better job." On the machine side, the purest algorithmic news finder is Google News, which made waves in the media world when it debuted. With Google News, it's code, and not a team of editors, that decides which stories make it onto the front page.

Today Google News will even tailor the front page to your particular interests as determined by your news reading habits and search history (so long as you are willing to log in to Google with a user name).

Likewise, Tailrank, a San Francisco-based startup founded by Kevin Burton, also relies heavily on smart code to find cool stories—not just from news outlets, but also from tens of thousands of blogs.

Burton started Tailrank as a way to handle the information overload created by access to blogs and media outlets via RSS.

Now he uses Tailrank to read through his 2,000 subscriptions and filter up the most important entries, based on a secret sauce that includes a method of tracking how often stories or blog posts are linked to by others.

The site defaults to the top stories linked to around the web, and lets you switch to a filtered view based on sites you have listed as your favorites. You can set that list either by uploading from a newsreader or using a feature released last week that scans your browser for blogs you have recently visited.

On the humanity side of the man-machine wars, Digg uses a simpler method to find cool stories: humans clicking mouse buttons.

Digg users submit technology stories and then others can vote those picks up, down or simply lame. It's not personalized, but Digg users are fast to find new stories.

So far Digg is limited to technology news, but according to CEO Adelson, the company will be expanding to other "sections of the newspaper soon"—and it just might take on Google News as well.

http://www.wired.com/news/technology/0,70382-0.html?tw=wn_index_27

CNET News.com, March 17, 2006

## If you give a bot a basketball...

WHAT BETTER WAY to get kids interested in math and science than robot sports? CNET's Stephanie Olsen finds out.

If you want a glimpse of the future of technology in the United States, look no further than the Ice Weasels, Space Cookies and Cheesy Poofs.

No, these aren't code names of secret projects at Google. They're the names of high school teams competing here this weekend for top merit in the 15th annual robotics contest sponsored by FIRST (For the Inspiration and Recognition of Science and Technology), a nonprofit founded by Segway inventor Dean Kamen. With about $10,000 worth of donated hardware and software, high school students were given roughly six weeks to assemble a functioning robot that can move around a court and shoot Nerf basketballs for points, which is this year's chosen game.

"They give you a game that's too hard, with a time line too short and too much stuff, and the kids have to do what they can with it," said Jon Rockman, a physics teacher at the all-girls high school Castilleja in Palo Alto, Calif. Rockman is also team adviser to the green-clad Gatorbotics.

The kooky team names and oddly challenging game belie the genuine techno wizardry and teamwork on display Thursday at San Jose University's event center.

The youngsters' enthusiasm for their robots offers a ray of hope for the future of science and math in the United States at a time when many educators are concerned about test scores and flailing interest among young people in the fields.


If you give a bot a basketball...

Still, it's a truly odd scene, much like a cross between a Nickelodeon fun house and a BattleBot show. The field of play is about the size of a small soccer field, but it's hardly intimidating, cluttered with candy-colored Nerf balls. Instead of bot fights, the robots try to throw the Nerfs through round holes in translucent walls at each end of the field, and electronic scoreboards on the wall tick higher when a ball makes it through.

A giant overhead video screen and clubby rave music in the background add a teeny-bopper MTV concert feel. If they're not playing a practice round, high school students clad in jeans and team T-shirts are either milling around (sometimes in hand-holding pairs) or engrossed in welding, drilling or just fiddling with their bots.

The competition is a community effort. Part of the challenge is for teens to find and work with mentors who are experts in technology and science.

The Gatorbotics, for example, have been working with Emily Moth, an engineer at Ideo in Palo Alto. Homestead High School in Cupertino, Calif., worked with Ron Crane, one of the founders of 3Com. Homestead's team is sponsored by Apple Computer co-founder Steve Wozniak, who is an alumnus of the school.

http://news.com.com/If+you+give+a+bot+a+basketball.../2100-11394_36050969.html?tag=st_lh